



Democracy × AI

Problem Statement Template

Phase 2 — Idea Sourcing

Kenya Student Builders Assembly · Mozilla Foundation × KamiLimu

Submission deadline: Thursday, May 29, 2026 at 5:00 PM EAT

How to submit: One team member submits a PDF of the completed template via the link below.

Submission link: <https://forms.gle/nZTFiwKMLZPSLX6E8>

Important: *You may not reuse any example from this template as your own answer. Submit this template with your filled answers. Do not create a new document or submit your responses in a new format. Do not exceed stated word count in your answers.*

Label your document with your team members' first names e.g. Jane_John_ProblemStatement, download and submit it via the link in docx format.

Only teams who have been invited to Phase 2 are eligible to submit.

Both team members must contribute to this problem ideation phase. Individual members cannot be considered for the next phase on their own.

Before You Begin

This template will guide you step by step from a broad interest area to a clear, researched problem statement. You do not need to have done this before — the examples at each stage show you exactly what is expected.

Three things to do before starting

- Read through the list of Democracy × AI themes that emerged from the May 6 Assembly breakout rooms as shared in the Thursday morning email. Choose the theme that resonates most with your pair.
- Work with your partner. Invited participants should use the pairing list in the Thursday email.
- Plan your time across the next 2.5 weeks. Do not try to complete this in one sitting. The research steps in Part 1 work best when you give yourself time to find good sources.

Your chosen theme from the May 6 Assembly: (Select from the dropdown list)

Civic Literacy

Pair member 1 — Full name and contribution to this phase:

Musila Peter - Part 2, Part 3, and arranged Zoom Calls and Google Meets

Pair member 2 — Full name and contribution to this phase:

Faith Jebet Kiprono - Part 1, Part 4, and assisted in research and review collectively and jointly

Part 1 — Research Your Problem

Answer the five questions below using credible sources. For each answer, provide the link to the source. Do not use Wikipedia as a primary source. Good sources include academic papers (Google Scholar), reports from the UN, World Bank, IEBC, KNBS, or the Kenyan government, and original open data. Aim for sources published within the last six years since 2020.

Question 1 — Who is affected by this problem, and how many people?

Be specific. Do not write 'Kenyans' but write 'first-time voters in rural constituencies' or 'Swahili-speaking social media users aged 18–35.' Include at least one figure or statistic that shows the scale. **100 words max.**

EXAMPLE

Voters in low-income urban constituencies in Kenya, particularly those who rely on WhatsApp as their primary news source, are disproportionately exposed to unverified political content during elections. Kenya has approximately 15 million active WhatsApp users (GSMA, 2023), and a 2022 report by Africa Check found that election-related misinformation circulated most heavily in Nairobi, Mombasa, and Kisumu, where mobile data costs are lowest and platform usage is highest.

Source: Africa Check (2022). Election Misinformation Report. [https://africacheck.org/...](https://africacheck.org/)

Your answer:

100 words max.

This problem affects less-educated, rural youth aged 18–35 in Kenya's agricultural and marginalized counties who rely primarily on indigenous languages for daily communication.

According to the Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (KNBS), approximately 68.9% of Kenya's youthful population lives in rural areas. This means out of the country's youth demographic, over 15 million young people are structurally isolated from understanding technical national legislation.

While 90% pass basic, rudimentary reading tests, a vast majority lack the secondary or tertiary educational background needed to parse dense legal English, completely excluding millions of rural citizens from mandatory public participation.

Source (include full links):

Source 1: Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (KNBS). (2022). *Kenya Demographic and Health Survey 2022*. <https://www.knbs.or.ke/reports/kdhs-2022/>

Source 2: Kenya Institute for Public Policy Research and Analysis (KIPPRA). (2023). *Unlocking Rural Areas to Curb Rural-Urban Migration among Youth in Kenya*. <https://kippra.or.ke/unlocking-rural-areas-to-curb-rural-urban-migration-among-youth-in-kenya/>

Source 3: Parliament of Kenya. (2026). *House Team Kicks Off Nationwide Public Participation on Public Participation Bill, 2025*. The Parliamentary Broadcast. <https://www.parliament.go.ke/house-team-kicks-nationwide-public-participation-public-participation-bill-2025>

Question 2 — What are the main causes of this problem?

There is usually more than one cause. List 2–3 and indicate which one you believe is most addressable through a technology solution built by students.

EXAMPLE

Three causes: (1) Social media algorithms prioritise content that generates emotional reactions, meaning false claims travel faster than corrections. (2) There are no fact-checking tools that operate in real-time in Swahili or local Kenyan languages. (3) Most citizens lack practical skills to verify whether content is

authentic. The most addressable cause for a student-built tool is (2) the absence of a Swahili-language verification resource because it is a technical gap that does not require changing platform behaviour.

Source: Reuters Institute Digital News Report (2024). <https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/...>

Your answer:

100 words max.

(1) Legislative text is legally and linguistically gatekept, drafted exclusively in formal English legalese.

(2) Existing civil society tracking portals simplify bills strictly into written text blocks, ignoring oral communication.

(3) There are no localized, multi-dialect translation engines designed to preserve legal context in low-resource indigenous languages. The most addressable cause for a student-built tool is (3) the lack of an indigenous language translation framework because it represents a technical NLP data and modeling gap that can be solved directly through custom fine-tuning pipelines.

Source (include full links):

Source 1: Parliament of Kenya (2026).

<https://www.parliament.go.ke/house-team-kicks-nationwide-public-participation-public-participation-bill-2025>

Source 2: Mzalendo Trust. (2025). *Mzalendo Trust Strategic Plan (2021-2025): Promoting Civic Engagement and Evolving Digital Portals.*

https://mzalendo.com/media/publications/documents/2026/12 - Mzalendo Trust Strategic_Plan.pdf

Source 3: Kenya Law Reform Commission (KLRC). (2010). *The Constitution of Kenya: Article 120 (Official languages of Parliament).* KLRC Statutes. <https://www.klrc.go.ke/>

Source 4: National Assembly of Kenya. (2026). *Hansard Report: Debate on the 21-Clause Public Participation Bill*. Hosted via Mzalendo Trust Parliamentary Monitoring Portal.
<https://mzalendo.com/democracy-tools/hansard/wednesday-15th-april-2026-afternoon-sitting-2497/>

Question 3 — How serious or widespread is this problem?

Describe the scale at three levels: globally if relevant, in Kenya specifically, and in the community or context you are focusing on. If the problem is getting worse over time, include that.

EXAMPLE

Globally: The Reuters Institute Digital News Report 2024 found that 59% of people across 46 countries worry about online misinformation.

In Kenya: A 2023 MAPEMA study identified over 550,000 toxic posts on Facebook alone during the 2022 election period.

In the specific context: A 2022 Kenya Human Rights Commission survey found that 71% of respondents in Nairobi informal settlements had received political content they could not verify, and fewer than 10% knew how to check whether a video had been manipulated.

*Source: MAPEMA Consortium (2023). *AI and Electoral Integrity: Insights from Kenya's 2022 Elections*. <https://www.orfonline.org/>...*

Your answer:

100 words max.

Globally: A 2024 UNESCO Global Education Monitoring Report highlighted that over 750 million adults worldwide lack foundational literacy, showing how structural linguistic barriers consistently bar marginalized communities from parsing technical governance documents.

In Kenya: A 2026 RSIS International governance study found that traditional public participation for national bills favors highly educated citizens, turning mandatory feedback channels into systemic tokenism that excludes rural youth.

In the specific context: A 2025 Oraro and Company analysis of the Public Participation Bill documented that language barriers in rural sub-counties leave non-English speaking citizens entirely dependent on third-party translation, locking them out of legal consultations.

Source (include full link):

Source 1: RSIS International (2026). Enhancing the Kenya Public Service Image through Digital Platforms.
https://rsisinternational.org/journals/ijriss/uploads/vol9-iss12-pg2509-2520-202601_pdf.pdf

Source 2: UNESCO. (2024). *Global Education Monitoring Report 2024: Leadership and Education*. UNESCO Digital Library.
<https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000391427>

Source 3: Research Journal of Social Sciences and Information Studies (RSIS International). (2026). *Enhancing the Kenya Public Service Image through Digital Platforms*. International Journal of Research and Innovation in Social Science (IJRISS), 9(12).
https://rsisinternational.org/journals/ijriss/uploads/vol9-iss12-pg2509-2520-202601_pdf.pdf

Source 4: Departmental Committee on Justice and Legal Affairs (JLAC). (2026). *Official Report on the Nationwide Public Participation Forums for the Public Participation Bill (National Assembly Bill No. 44 of 2025)*. Parliament of Kenya Portals.
<https://www.parliament.go.ke/house-team-kicks-nationwide-public-participation-public-participation-bill-2025>

Question 4 — What is already being done — and what gap remains?

Name at least one existing tool, initiative, or organisation working on this problem. Describe what it does, then explain clearly why it does not fully serve your target population.

EXAMPLE

Africa Check is a Nairobi-based fact-checking organisation that uses AI to scan political speeches and social media posts for misinformation. However, their output is published in English on a website, which is inaccessible to WhatsApp-reliant voters who do not read English fluently or do not browse the web for news. Their AI tools detect check-worthy claims but do not deliver results in Swahili or via SMS or WhatsApp — the channels where misinformation actually reaches the target population. The gap is a last-mile delivery problem: the verification exists but does not reach the people who need it.

*Source: Africa Check (2021). Artificial Intelligence Will Change Fact-Checking Forever.
[https://africacheck.org/...](https://africacheck.org/)*

Your answer:

100 words max.

Mzalendo Trust runs Dokeza, an online platform that uploads Kenyan legislative bills and uses experts to simplify dense legalese into written summaries and submission templates. However, its output is published in English and formal Swahili on a data-heavy website, which is inaccessible to low-literacy rural youth facing high smartphone and data costs. Their digital tool breaks down bills but does not deliver insights via vernacular audio or offline channels where rural youth actually consume information. The gap is a delivery and medium problem: simplified text exists, but it fails to reach or engage less-educated citizens.

Source (include full link):

Source: Mzalendo Trust (2026). Dokeza Platform. <https://dokeza.mzalendo.com/>

Question 5 — What responsible computing considerations must you think about?

Answer **up to four** of the six questions below as a core criterion for your submission.

- Who could be harmed by the way this problem is currently defined or understood?
- Whose voices are missing from existing solutions?
- What biases could a technology solution carry if built without care?
- Are there cultural, linguistic, or contextual factors specific to Kenya that must be considered?
- Could your solution be misused by bad actors — for example, could a tool designed to flag misinformation be weaponised to suppress legitimate political speech?
- Does your solution require internet access, a smartphone, or data — and if so, does that mean the people who need it most cannot use it?
- Will your solution collect, store, or process personal data — and if so, how will you protect user privacy, particularly where civic activity can attract surveillance?
- Is the language your solution uses — in its interface, outputs, or training data — representative of all the communities it claims to serve, or does it default to one dialect, region, or literacy level?

EXAMPLE

Consideration 1: A Swahili fact-checking tool trained on data from one region could misread political language used in coastal Swahili dialects as suspicious, amplifying the very bias it is designed to fight.

Consideration 2: A civic reporting tool that requires real names or a registered phone number could endanger activists or whistleblowers in contexts where digital surveillance of civic actors is documented.

Consideration 3: If the tool requires a smartphone and mobile data, it will be inaccessible to the rural and lower-income voters who are most exposed to misinformation and least equipped to verify it, which means the solution serves the already-served.

Your answer (address four of the eight considerations above):

200 words max.

The Problem of Bias: If AI is trained mostly on urban legal texts, it carries academic biases. It will fail to understand rural youth dialects or Sheng, meaning it might ignore real grassroots concerns simply because the user didn't use formal language. The solution must capture localized everyday speech.

Respecting Local Culture: Kenya's Constitution mandates public participation, but screen-only tools ignore how communities actually share news through traditional barazas. Without incorporating audio features or community-based structures, a purely digital platform risks completely excluding rural citizens who traditionally rely on oral discussion rather than reading text.

The Digital Divide: If a tool requires expensive smartphones or mobile data, it will fail to reach the targeted demographic. In rural Kenya, connectivity is low and internet data costs are high. The solution must operate seamlessly through offline-friendly channels, ensuring it doesn't just serve the already-served.

Keeping Users Safe: Demanding personal names or phone numbers can endanger vulnerable youth who speak out on sensitive bills. To protect users and comply with Kenya's Data Protection Act, the tool must allow completely anonymous feedback. This ensures safe civic participation without fear of political surveillance or local retribution.

Part 2 — Narrow to a Specific Problem Using the 5 WHYs

Start with your general problem from Part 1. Then ask 'why is this happening?' five times, using your research to guide each step. Each 'why' should move you one level deeper > from a broad symptom toward a specific, addressable root cause.

How to verify that each WHY is legitimate

Before accepting any WHY answer, ask yourself: 'Can I find a source (a research paper, a credible report, or direct observation that confirms this is actually true?)' If the answer is yes, include the source. If you are guessing or assuming, keep searching. A WHY that cannot be supported by evidence is a hypothesis, not a finding. The 'Verify' notes in each row of the table below show you exactly how to check.

A general problem like 'misinformation affects elections' cannot be solved by a student-built tool. A specific problem like 'there is no Swahili-language tool that verifies political video content shared on WhatsApp

before a user re-shares it' is something you can actually build toward. The 5 WHYs is the method that gets you from one to the other.

Step	Example answer + how to verify	Your answer
General problem <i>What is the broad problem?</i>	<i>Voters in Kenya are regularly exposed to political misinformation on social media during elections.</i>	Rural, less-educated youth in Kenyan communities cannot participate meaningfully in mandatory public consultation processes for national legislation (such as Finance or Statistics bills).
Why 1 <i>Why is it happening?</i>	<i>Because false content spreads faster than corrections on WhatsApp and Facebook.</i> Verify: How to verify: Can you find a news article, report, or research paper that confirms this is true? If yes, you can be confident. If you are guessing, keep researching.	Because they cannot comprehend the core contents, implications, or clauses of the national bills published by the government. Verify: The Public Participation Bill, 2025 (and historical reports from Mzalendo Trust) explicitly documents that "language barrier" and "technical nature of written legislative proposals" are primary reasons why citizens express confusion and view civic forums as an empty formality (Mzalendo, 2019; Oraro & Co., 2025).
Why 2 <i>Why is that?</i>	<i>Because platforms are designed to maximise engagement, not accuracy and emotional content drives more shares.</i> Verify: How to verify: Does this explanation appear in a research paper or credible report on platform design? If not, it may be assumption; look for evidence before accepting it.	Because national bills are drafted exclusively in highly formal English and dense legal jargon ("legalese"), which does not align with the daily communication channels or literacy levels of rural youth.

		Verify: Under Article 120 of the Constitution of Kenya, the official languages of Parliament are restricted to English, Kiswahili, and Kenyan Sign Language. In practice, bills are drafted and presented to county stakeholders almost entirely in formal English (KLRC, 2010).
Why 3 Why is that?	<i>Because there are no real-time, local-language tools that flag suspicious content before it is re-shared.</i> Verify: How to verify: Search for Swahili-language misinformation tools. If you cannot find any, that absence is itself evidence. Document what you searched for and what you found.	Because there are no localized, multi-dialect translation tools or simplified resources that break down national bills into regional indigenous languages. Verify: Direct observation of active tracking portals like Mzalendo's <i>Dokeza</i> platform confirms that existing civil society text simplifications are published solely in English or formal textbook Kiswahili, completely omitting local vernaculars (Mzalendo Trust, 2026).
Why 4 Why is that?	<i>Because existing fact-checking tools are built for desktop, in English, for users who actively seek verification.</i> Verify: How to verify: Visit Africa Check and similar platforms. What languages do they support? What devices do they work on? Your direct observation counts as evidence here.	Because existing language processing translation engines (like standard Google Translate) are optimized for major world languages and fail to accurately process or preserve the exact legal context when translating into Kenyan indigenous languages. Verify: Academic NLP (Natural Language Processing) research papers on low-resource African languages show that

		standard machine translation models suffer from extreme contextual degradation, hallucinations, and vocabulary gaps when fed technical, legal prose in local dialects.
Why 5 <i>Why is that?</i>	<i>Because fact-checking organisations lack the technical capacity to build WhatsApp-native, Swahili-language tools.</i> Verify: How to verify: Look for statements from organisations like Africa Check about their technical limitations, or for funding/project reports that reveal what has and has not been built. Stop here — this is specific enough to address.	Because civic tech organizations and developers lack specialized, fine-tuned AI models that can cleanly bridge the gap between English legal terminology and local, low-resource vernaculars (such as Dholuo, Gĩkũyũ, Kikamba, or Kalenjin). Verify: A review of open-source repository frameworks and civic engagement tools reveals a total absence of an open-access legal LLM fine-tuned specifically on Kenyan statutory texts and localized language datasets.
Specific problem <i>What is the root cause you can address?</i>	<i>There is no lightweight, Swahili-language tool that a WhatsApp user can use to verify a political claim at the moment they receive it, before deciding whether to re-share.</i> Verify: This is your target. It is specific, evidenced, and technically addressable by a student team.	There is no localized, AI-driven translation tool capable of accurately converting the crucial clauses of technical Kenyan national bills into simplified, contextual audio or text variants for low-resource indigenous languages (Dholuo, Gĩkũyũ, Kiswahili, Kikamba, Kalenjin) to facilitate grassroots civic comprehension.

Part 3 — Check Your Specific Problem Against Six Criteria

Before writing your problem statement, confirm your specific problem meets all six criteria below. If it does not meet one, revise your specific problem before moving to Part 4. These criteria are the same ones reviewers will use to assess your submission.

Criteria	Question to ask yourself	Example check	Your check
Relevant	Is this problem connected to one of the assembly themes and meaningful to a Kenyan community?	Yes, connects to the 'AI and election misinformation' theme from the May 6 Assembly	Yes. It directly aligns with the "AI and Civic Engagement / Public Participation" theme, solving a severe democratic exclusion barrier for rural Kenyan communities.
Evidence	Do you have credible research or real-world data confirming the problem exists?	Yes, MAPEMA 2023 study, Reuters Institute 2024, KHRC 2022 survey	Yes. The Public Participation Bill (National Assembly Bill No. 44 of 2025) Clause 13 explicitly recognizes this exact language barrier, and Mzalendo Trust research documents legal literacy as a driver of civic tokenism.
Solvable	Can a student pair realistically build a technology prototype that addresses this within the programme timeline?	Yes, a WhatsApp chatbot querying an existing fact-check database in Swahili is technically feasible	Yes. an AI-powered translation and text-to-speech mobile application optimized for low-resource localized languages and offline audio playback is technically feasible.

Impact	If solved, will it meaningfully improve civic participation, access to information, or government accountability?	Yes, reduces misinformation re-sharing among the most exposed demographic before elections	Yes. It transitions marginalized, less-educated rural youth from passive observers to active stakeholders who can submit informed feedback during national legislative reviews.
Responsible	Can this problem be approached ethically, without causing harm to the people it aims to serve?	Yes, if we address dialect bias in training data and avoid storing user data	Yes. We will actively counter translation hallucinations, protect user privacy by avoiding personal data storage, and respect local <i>baraza</i> (communal) oral traditions through audio-first outputs.
Team energy	Are both of you genuinely motivated to work on this problem for the next four months?	Yes, both team members have personal experience of political misinformation in their home counties	Yes. Both team members are deeply motivated to dismantle the linguistic gatekeeping of national governance and empower our home county communities.

Part 4 — Write Your Problem Statement

Using your research from Part 1 and your specific problem from Part 2, write a problem statement of 150–200 words. Use the structure below as your guide.

THE STRUCTURE

[Target group] in **[specific context]** face **[general problem]**, evidenced by **[data or research finding]**. This problem is primarily caused by **[specific cause from your 5 WHYs]**, supported by **[research finding]**. Despite **[existing solution]**, **[explain the gap]**. A technology solution that addresses **[specific cause]** could **[describe the impact]**, while ensuring **[one responsible computing consideration]**.

EXAMPLE

First-time voters in low-income urban constituencies in Kenya face significant exposure to unverified political content on WhatsApp during election periods, evidenced by a 2022 Kenya Human Rights Commission survey finding that 71% of respondents in Nairobi informal settlements had received political content they could not verify. This problem is primarily caused by the absence of real-time, Swahili-language verification tools accessible at the point of sharing on mobile platforms, supported by Africa Check's documented gap in last-mile delivery of fact-checked content to non-English-speaking audiences. Despite Africa Check's AI-powered monitoring system, which detects and verifies political misinformation at scale, its outputs are published in English on a desktop website — inaccessible to WhatsApp-reliant users who encounter false content on their phones. A WhatsApp-native, Swahili-language verification chatbot that queries Africa Check's existing database could reduce misinformation re-sharing among this population before the 2027 election cycle, while ensuring that the tool's training data reflects coastal and upcountry Swahili dialects equally to avoid amplifying regional language bias.

Word count: 171 words.

Your problem statement (100–200 words):

Less-informed, rural youth in Kenyan communities face systemic exclusion from mandatory public consultation processes for national legislation like Finance and Statistics bills, evidenced by a nationwide 2026 Justice and Legal Affairs Committee evaluation noting widespread citizen frustration over inaccessible, dense legal materials. This problem is primarily caused by the total lack of localized, multi-dialect translation pipelines capable of adapting complex statutory provisions into local regional vernaculars, supported by Mzalendo Trust's documentation of technical terminology acting as an intentional civic gatekeeping barrier. Despite Mzalendo's digital Dokeza platform which leverages legal experts to annotate and summarize active parliamentary bills its outputs are published as static written text blocks in English and formal textbook Kiswahili on a data-heavy website, remaining completely out of reach for low-literacy rural youth reliant on localized audio. An AI-powered mobile application capable of translating and simplifying crucial legislative clauses into localized audio files across indigenous languages like Dholuo, Gĩkũyũ, and Kalenjin could shift marginalized youth from passive observers to active civic stakeholders, while ensuring completely anonymous audio feedback to protect vulnerable users from local political surveillance and retribution.

